

 The Digital World

A Round-up Of Technology News From Across The Globe

UNITED STATES

Despite support from only 1 per cent of the public, the State Department has finalised plans to go ahead with passports containing RFID chips. It plans to have all passports RFID-enabled by October of 2006.

**FINLAND**

Too many mobile phones are turning up in the sewage system of the Helsinki metropolitan area. At the sewage plant in Viikinkaari, a thousand tons of solid junk is collected every year, a lot of this being in the form of mobile phones. Talk about e-waste!

UNITED KINGDOM

The British Library, which holds 13 million books, will begin digitising its collection and make 25 million pages of it available online. These will be available for free on Microsoft Web sites: Microsoft has pledged \$1.7 million a year to pay for the project, probably in response to Google Print.

**CHINA**

The number of Internet users in China reached 103 million in June of this year. China's Internet sector is now the world's second largest. This despite Chinese authorities doing their best to control the medium.

JAPAN

Tokyo offers the cheapest broadband amongst major world cities, and Japan claims its broadband is the cheapest. Flets ADSL in Tokyo charges just ¥4,850 per month (Rs 1,850).

AUSTRALIA

Australian telecom major Telstra recently announced it will roll-out a W-CDMA network that will cover 98 per cent of Australia's population! This bolsters the idea that mobile can play a prime role in providing rural broadband connectivity.

between identical twins and spot family members! In addition to this, the software can also read street signs in a photograph and thus identify a location. The service's context-based approach looks at 50 variables in a photograph, including hair, eye colour, shirt colour, height, sex, etc.

Munjal Shah, CEO of Riya, says the software's mission is to make every photo in the world searchable.

Of course, to tag a photo by identifying its contents, the software needs to be trained. The training software is available on the Internet and is currently offered for Windows-based computers. A user would train the software by identifying, or tagging, individuals in their photos. As the software learns who's in your pictures, it begins to auto-tag the photographs, quickly scanning the rest of your photos and identifying each person it can recognise.

Photos uploaded to this free service for tagging can be made private, or users can choose to make images

viewable by friends in the photos or by the general public. Friends may search each others' images and even add their own tags. Riya plans to make the images and metadata exportable to 'any application.'

HARDWARE VIRTUALISATION**As Good As Two**

Earlier last month, Intel launched two Pentium IV chips—the Pentium IV 672 and 662 processors—which will support a technology that allows computers to simultaneously run several operating systems, and also tools such as anti-virus and other high-end applications such as image processing and video editing software. The technology, called 'virtualisation', is said to impact the multitasking capabilities of a PC tremendously. Intel claims these processors are the first desktop processors to have these capabilities.

**Three Incredibly Useful Sites**

Et Cetera

www.bplans.com**Bplans.com**

Are you looking for information to help start your own business? First of all, chalk a business plan. And a visit to Bplans.com will do you a whole lot of good. It has it all—legal information, business plan software, 500 sample plans—you name it.

www.avantGo.com**AvantGo.com**

If you're tired of the way Web pages look on your handheld device, AvantGo is the answer to your prayers. The company offers customised Web content from Reuters, *Wired*, AccuWeather and *The New York Times*. You just need to sync your handheld once beforehand daily, and your favourite sites will travel with you all the time. And yes, the service is free!

www.grokker.com**Grokker.com**

Grokker returns query results organised into a visual map. What this means is your search results are no longer mere hyperlinks on a white page: they're colourful and cross-referenced. And how good are the search results? Well, it depends on what kind of search you're conducting. Go ahead, give Grokker a shot!